The Victory Explosions

By Derrick Brown

INTRODUCTION

When have you failed? You have. It's a given. It's inevitable. But . . . I'll admit . . . it's not a popular conversation to have – the one where we admit we've failed. Winston Churchill once said: "Success is not final, failure is not fatal: it is the courage to continue that counts." In this poetry selection, Derrick Brown reflects on his first memory of failure in what he (in hind-site) calls . . . The Victory Explosions.

The Victory Explosions by Derrick Brown.

I was in the fifth grade and I got my a** kicked by a
fourth grader.
Good times.
I try to remember my youth.
It evaporated into 76 memories.
One memory when you were young
was that you believed the earth was made perfect by
god
and that humans fouled it up.

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That sin was something we gave birth to a
as god shook his head at our idiocy and said
"how could they choose terror and loss?"
You didn't think god ever really wanted perfection
if he designed the things he made with an instinct to
screw up.
Fighting it sometimes failing is beautiful and hard
screwing up is part of the program.
Call it sin, call it human
maybe there are codes built inside of darkness needing
light
and vice versa.
It did not shake your belief in an existence of a god,
but it shook your belief in the bland necessity for
perfection.
It birthed the belief that the human who could figure
out
the balance of a hunger for winning
and a deep respect for losing would win the life trophy.
You go back to the first year you learned to daydream in
a clothing rack.

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The first year butterflies bloomed adrenalized in your
wet guts.
In the fifth grade you tempted everything
bicycle wheelie spinning
the smell of girls
pencils at war
dismantled radios
launching off the swing set into the air.
Your first sensation of flight.
An innocent season for getting you're a** royally kicked
by a boy who thought it would be a nice sign of his love.
Adam White heard I liked his girl and kissed her
underwater
at a Dutch pool party French style
which is weird for a fifth grader.
These were skill sets in the fifth grade my tongue was
not prepared for.
I didn't know who started the rumor
but I was about to pay for it with the cash of my face.
The same field we chased girls together in

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the strong freckled Adam challenged me to my first fist
fight.
I felt like a coward in a costume of a coward.
I was skinnier than a dead model.
No matter how much I denied the rumor
freckles popping from his face like brail.
"Your a** is grass Derrick Brown!"
I know, I know.
The crowd gathered
I stared at them like a sparrow trapped in an airport
terminal
wanting the sky but stuck against the glass.
I stood there like a cricket in a junkyard of fiddles.
Unable to stop my legs from shaking music from my
knees.
He swore he loved her and that I would pay.
Forehead blistering, wrinkling like a crumbled valentine.
And where were the teachers?
That's what they're paid for.

What I wanted was mercy, but in the fifth grade

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mercy was just a word in the dictionary
and even I didn't know what it meant.
And he cocked.
His fists came out and crushed at my jaw
my eyes went black and all that I saw
was a shower of lightning bugs
children flashing into sunshine
teeth penetrating my cheek
children falling backwards
blood fertilizing the softball field.
But instead of freezing for some dumb reason
I stood up again and he struck me down once more.
Eyes ricocheting against the back of my skull.
The earth meeting my failure.
Legs buckling, skin wreaking with contact.
And for some dumb reason,
for some dumb stupid reason
I stood up again and he socked me with all his might.
Matchsticks lighting in my cheeks.
And I stood up again and he hit me so hard my mother's
eyes bled.

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And I fell again and I stood up again
and again
and again
and again
until he grew tired of socking me in the face and he just
left.
And everybody left until I stood there alone
baptized in my own warm blood.
I now knew the cost of the saddened sponge
and slop of a girl's ridiculous lips because guess what?
We did kiss underwater at her Dutch pool party.
Like aqua spies.
And it was worth it.
There's nothing for me to learn from winning.
It is losing that has yielded the unforgettable lessons.
Losing is pregnant with chance.
Victory escorts loss to every dance.
That is harmony
harmony
harmony.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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